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Greetings, it is I, a traveler from the year 2016. I have come to your strange time not to see how things worked out with that Donald Trump character or even whether everyone is still losing their heads over [Hamilton](#), but to remind you of something you may have forgotten: *Stranger Things* used to be good.

Back in my time, you see, '80s nostalgia was a relatively new phenomenon, and Matt and Ross Duffer approached the period and the pop culture that defined it—Steven Spielberg's suburban mythmaking, Stephen King's tales of small-town horror—with such reverence and [attention to detail](#) that it felt at times as if someone had discovered the episodes in the back of an abandoned Blockbuster. Poised midway between their fresh-faced tween protagonists and their worse-for-wear parents, the then-32-year-old Duffer twins connected with the crumbling innocence of children who are just starting to learn about the terrors and disappointments of adulthood, the monsters that hide in the dark and the moms and dads who have forgotten how they ever loved each other.

Watching *Stranger Things*' fifth and final season, it's hard to remember that this earlier show ever existed. The series' massive success has given the Duffers practically unlimited resources—the new season, by some reports, cost as much as \$480 million, 10 times the cost of the first, and more than any *Avengers* movie—but they've increased its scale while narrowing its scope. We learn within the first few minutes of the new season that Hawkins, Indiana, is under military quarantine, with some story about unexplained phenomena covering up for the Vecna-spawned earthquakes that tore a giant red rift down the middle of the sleepy town. But it's not just Hawkins that feels cut off from the world. It's *Stranger Things* itself, a show now sealed in an airless, impenetrable bubble of stagnant characters and snarled lore.

After a quick flashback to the night of Will Byers' abduction from the very first episode, the fifth season jumps forward four years to the end of 1987, which puts its principal characters—Will (Noah Schnapp), Mike (Finn Wolfhard), Dustin (Gaten Matarazzo), Lucas (Caleb McLaughlin), and Eleven (Millie Bobby Brown)—into their midteens. Given that it's been 10 years since *Stranger Things* started filming, and more than three since the last episode of Season 4 was released, the show had to choose between acknowledging the passage of time or [looking like Ben Platt in *Dear Evan Hansen*](#). (McLaughlin, the eldest of the young actors, is now 24, eight years older than his character.) For one thing, it's not nearly long enough to account for the actors' fully adult appearances: Though it's been a decade since the show went into production, the characters have aged, in total, less than half that. (Schnapp in particular seems to have been draped in layers of baggy clothes in a vain attempt to make him resemble a scrawny 16-year-old.) But it also creates narrative issues the show seems to have no interest in addressing, namely what would happen to a nondescript Midwestern town if the government cut it off from the rest of the country for the better part of a year.

The end of *Stranger Things*' fourth season seemed to promise, even mandate, that the existence of the demonic alternate dimension known as the Upside Down would become a matter of public record, rather than a secret shared by a handful of heartland nerds and the governments of several superpowers. But the Duffers hand-wave that possibility with a few brute-force sentences about the “giant metal Band-Aid” the military has used to cover the fissures that literally split Hawkins in two, a cataclysm the community evidently now considers so humdrum that the kids use those metal plates for warm-weather sledding.

Given the way the show's early seasons tapped into Cold War paranoia and the Satanic Panic of the 1980s, affirmative proof of government conspiracies and supernatural goings-on ought to send Hawkins into a wide-scale panic. Instead, life appears to have continued on much as usual: Mike's parents still hate each other, Dustin is still getting bullied (although he's now more inclined to fight back), and Will is still, obviously, gay, despite the fact that no one seems ready to admit it. Granted, the 1980s were a less enlightened, more openly homophobic time, but assuming that the show is saving its big reveal for its final episodes—after this batch of four, three more arrive Christmas Day, with the series finale on Dec. 31—the show will have spent something on the order of 40 hours building up to the bombshell that one of its male characters likes boys.

You'd think his mother, Joyce (Winona Ryder), would at least have figured out by now. But the show that restarted Ryder's career nearly a decade ago no longer seems to know what to do with her. Joyce's determination to find her son no matter how crazy her attempts might look drove *Stranger Things*' earliest episodes; she hammered Christmas lights to the wall with as much manic intensity as Richard Dreyfuss brought to sculpting mashed potatoes in [Close Encounters of the Third Kind](#). Now, though, she merely seems frantic, as the show's kids have become more self-sufficient (and more handy with firearms) and as Jim Hopper (David Harbour) has transformed from a potbellied police chief into a sword-wielding action hero. What's a mom to do, except remind her son not to go off and fight Vecna without first putting on a hat?

About Vecna—at one point in the season, a new character requires quick instruction in the nature of *Stranger Things*' big bad, and after one person refers to him as Vecna, another as Henry Creel, and a third as One, the newcomer cries out in exasperation, "That's too many names!" If nothing else, the feeble attempt at [transferring the franchise to the Broadway stage](#)—and especially the documentary about the chaos behind its creation—revealed that the Duffers have never had either a master plan or, more fatally, the skill to write themselves out of the corners in which their ad hoc storytelling leaves them stranded. So they fall back on fan service and pop-culture scavenging, with the fifth season's major innovation being that the reference points shift from [Dungeons & Dragons](#) to [A Wrinkle in Time](#).

One of TV's most particular pleasures is getting to watch a show's cast grow up in something resembling real time. It's like living with the characters in a way that movies have to go to [extraordinary lengths](#) to emulate. And *Stranger Things*' cast has grown, maturing into actors more than capable of carrying their own projects. But the show hasn't matured with them. Like Netflix's other reigning auteurs—the [Russos](#), [Zack Snyder](#)—the Duffers have been given free rein to indulge, and have used that freedom to repeat themselves, over and over again.

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